

LANGUAGE LESSONS
Children learning Gujarati at a school in Rajkot

a medium other than Gujarati and are studying it as a language subject in varying degrees—or not at all—in primary classes. They may seem to be in a minority, but Patel points out that as English is the "language of aspiration", English-medium schools are on the rise—3,478 or 35 per cent of the total—and even penetrating the state's semi-urban areas.

Gujarati, linguists fear, will stop being a language of literate knowledge and could be reduced to an oral language in a few decades. Litterateurs are already alarmed at the distinct fall in publication of original Gujarati literature. In 2020, the last time the Gujarat education board held regular Class 10 exams, 14.5 per cent of students who had done their entire schooling in Gujarati medium, ironically, flunked the Gujarati language paper.

"Teachers are expected to not only teach the alphabet, but inspire students to read Gujarati literature too," reasons Patel. "But schools alone can't make a child proficient in the language without the parents' support. For decades now, Gujarati has stopped being 'cool'. The new law will bring it back in vogue, so to speak." Or, at least, it will ensure the state's children learn to read and write in their native tongue. ■

RAJASTHAN

VASUNDHARA, SELF-ATTESTED

By Rohit Parihar

The BJP high command, it seems, has had a late realisation that it may not be wise to alienate ex-chief minister Vasundhara Raje any further, especially in an election year. The 69-year-old Raje had declared some three weeks ago that she planned to hold her birthday celebrations on March 4 instead of on her birth date (March 8) so that it does not overlap with the Holi festivities. But true to form, the state leadership put a spanner in the works.

RAJE'S SALASAR RALLY ONCE AGAIN PROVED THAT IN THE RAJASTHAN BJP SHE IS THE ONLY LEADER CAPABLE OF PULLING IN THE CROWDS

Out of the blue, Rajasthan BJP chief Satish Poonia announced that the party would join its student wing, the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha (BJYM), in gheraoing the assembly on March 4 to protest against rising unemployment and the leaking of recruitment exam papers.

The assembly gherao could have happened on any other day, but the not-so-hidden agenda was to ensure that party legislators were present at the protests and not put in an appearance at Raje's event in Salasar in Churu district. Though not formally pegged as a political event, it was evident the birthday celebrations were to be a show of strength.

Raje camp insiders say as late as on March 2, she was extremely upset over the BJP state unit's move to sabotage her celebrations. Some prominent state leaders also apparently "expressed their anguish" to the high command through their contacts about being caught in a Catch-22 situation. Raje knows how to keep a low profile and abide by party discipline but, as one cohort put it grandly, "her blue blood boils the moment she is convinced there's been foul play against her". Fortunately, what was developing into an ugly situation for the party got defused after the Ashok Gehlot-led government decided to not hold an assembly session on March 4. Within hours, the BJP announced that its Rajasthan in-charge Arun Singh would be present at Poonia's protests but also attend Raje's celebrations. This, of course, meant that the unofficial 'sanction' against her event had been lifted.

Raje's birthday celebrations in Salasar were at a pilgrimage destination where Hanuman is the resident deity. As in previous years, it turned out to be a mega show, with the police and organisers having to work hard to ease the kilometres-long traffic jams and prevent stampedes, as nearly 100,000 gathered from all over the state. It also put all doubts to rest that she is the only BJP leader in Rajasthan with the charisma to command such crowds. For two days, she visited temples in the area and held long